

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

KILLING WITH SWEETNESS

When BCCI president Sourav Ganguly hosted Union home minister **Amit Shah** at his home in Kolkata on May 7, he arranged for a platter of Bengali delicacies for the BJP leader. Out of all the preparations, Shah loved *mishti doi* (sweet curd) the most. The suggestion to include it in the menu came from none other than West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee, one of the BJP's bitterest rivals. The sweetness of Mamata's gesture stayed on with Shah, known for his sweet tooth. He left Bengal, asking BJP leaders to dig their heels in and learn a lesson or two from Mamata on how to play the role of an Opposition leader.

PREZ PREDICTOR



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In 2012, **Nitish Kumar**—despite being an NDA ally—had supported UPA's presidential nominee, Pranab Mukherjee. Again, in 2017, now in alliance with RJD and Congress, Nitish supported NDA candidate Ram Nath Kovind. Both the men he backed became India's first citizens. Now, all eyes are trained on the Bihar CM before the presidential polls scheduled in July. On May 5, Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan flew into Patna to have an hour-long confab with Nitish, again underlining how eager the BJP is to secure Nitish's vote.

Not Your Meal Ticket

When **Rahul Gandhi** visited Telangana last week to take stock of the Congress's preparations for the assembly poll due next year, the party state unit left nothing to chance in its hospitality to the Gandhi scion. A sumptuous meal of Hyderabadi biryani was followed by Irani chai. It did little, though, to soften up Rahul. He asked local Congress leaders to be pro-active on the ground instead of rushing to Delhi, begging for tickets. He also twice advised them not to raise their grievances in the media and asked them to speak out in party forums. Violations will not be tolerated, he warned. The strong tea sure did its job.



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PUNJABI BY NATURE

With economist **Suman K. Bery** taking charge as vice-chairman of NITI Aayog, Punjabi-speaking experts now dominate the think tank. Barring V.K. Saraswat, other members—Ramesh Chand, Vinod Paul and Bery—are fluent in Punjabi. Bery is part of a clique of Punjabi economists who flaunted their proximity to the top two economic experts of the UPA regime—former PM Manmohan Singh and Planning Commission deputy chairman Montek Singh Ahluwalia.



RED-FACED PAWAR

The ever-alert **Sharad Pawar** was proved wrong twice in the past two weeks. First, author James W. Laine trashed Pawar's theory that the late Babasaheb Purandare was the source for his (Laine's) 'derogatory remarks' on Chhatrapati Shivaji in his 2003 book. Second, the Pune rural police withdrew a case against Sambhaji Bhide for the Koregaon-Bhima violence, citing lack of evidence. Pawar had first named Bhide as a conspirator. Both Purandare and Bhide were associated with the RSS, for which Pawar has no love lost.

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Romita Datta, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava and Kiran D. Tare